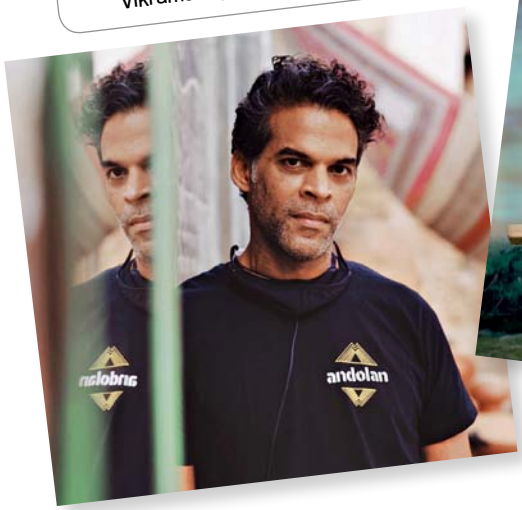


Vikramaditya Motwane





NORBERT HELKE

Atul Sabharwal

A still from *Jubilee*

There's a certain serendipity to Vikramaditya Motwane directing *Jubilee*, the latest Amazon Prime original on the enigmatic world of Hindi movies in the late 1940s and 1950s. Motwane's family is best known as the pioneers who brought Chicago Radio telephones, microphones and speakers to India, playing a key role in spreading the call for Indian independence. Motwane's grandfather, Harnam, apart from running the business also produced a film, *Andolan* (1951), an expensive albeit ill-fated venture starring the then relatively new Kishore Kumar. Motwane calls it the family's 'Voldemort', the one that wasn't spoken about. In fact, he would hear of it only after he decided to get into the world of films. *Jubilee* is Motwane's fifth production under the banner of his production house. He has named it Andolan Films.

Seated in Andolan's office in Mumbai, which, apart from humans, is also home to two canines, Dishoom and Heroine, Motwane reaches out for a frayed, bound album. It's a treasure trove with stills from the film. It ended up becoming one of the many sources to mine for "lights and moods" and "set references" as he and writer Atul Sabharwal developed *Jubilee*.

Sabharwal and Motwane are what one would call cinema geeks. You'll find them at screenings of restored old classics and see their names quoted in news articles or tagged on social media posts whenever the reel of an old Hindi film is found in a junk shop in some corner of Mumbai. In their early days, Sabharwal worked with Ram Gopal Varma, Motwane with Sanjay Leela Bhansali. They ultimately crossed paths in filmmaker Anurag Kashyap's office. "We've been in and out of each other's made and unmade projects and ideas and stories," says Sabharwal of his two-decade-long association with Motwane. In 2016, when Motwane called him for feedback on a series on the golden era of Hindi cinema, Sabharwal chose to be more generous and rewrote the pilot episode. Reading it, Motwane felt, Sabharwal should give the whole show a go. In it, Sabharwal saw an opportunity to tell a sweeping saga. Combining the stories he heard from his grandfather of Partition and refugee camps and Motwane's own family tales of its involvement in the freedom struggle, he felt, would make *Jubilee* "a more overarching story than just what was happening in the film industry". Their mutual 'keeda' for movies of the era certainly helped, but Motwane and Sabharwal turned to research agency Past Perfect to help them with details on "the socio-political climate at the time" as well as the crime reporting. That's not to say *Jubilee* doesn't take creative liberties, but it does feature seminal events in Indian cinema (the advent of playback singing, All India Radio banning Hindi film songs briefly, and so on) and touches on a young nation trying to find its feet. *Jubilee*, Motwane notes, operates on what he cheekily calls "true gossip" from the era. The show is inundated with 'easter eggs', essentially hidden motifs and references that

Jubilee is filled with hidden motifs and references that cinema buffs will love discovering and dissecting